

{Exam 3 Material}

Sex, Relationships, and Communication Notes COMM 1131

****** = exam questions “write this down”

[Quizlet](#)

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2/12/2024

Chapter 8

Making a Love Connection

Love and Attachment

Liking vs. loving

Liking includes:

- Affection, Trust, Respect
- Feeling comfortable together
- Enjoying spending time together

Loving includes:

- All of the “liking” characteristics PLUS
- A stronger emotional attachment
- Being willing to make sacrifices for the other person
- Emotional interdependence
- Behavioral interdependence
 - my partners actions affect me, my actions affect them

Attachment Theory

Key Ideas

- Beginning in infancy, we have an innate need to form attachments with others
- Early attachments influence future relational patterns
 - Caregivers (typically parents) can be tremendously influential
- Interaction children have with caregivers leads to the development of internal working models
 - *Working model of self*
 - the degree to which a child develops an internalized sense of self-worth that is not dependent on external validation
 - *Working model of others*
 - the degree to which a child expects others to be supportive and accepting (rather than rejecting)

Attachment styles

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- coherent patterns of emotion and social behavior that occur in close relationships
- Result from the extent to which parents exhibit caregiver attachment behaviors

Caregiver Attachment Behaviors

1. Sensitivity to signals
 - a. Detecting and interpreting the infant's signal correctly (for example, crying, laughing, facial expressions)
 - b. appropriately responding in a timely manner
2. Physical and psychological availability
 - a. Physically close
 - b. Emotionally open and available
3. Acceptance of the infant's needs

Ainsworth's attachment styles for children

1. Secure
 - a. positive working models of self
 - b. positive working model of others
 - c. Caregiver's communication patterns:
 - i. Caregiver consistently exhibits caregiver attachment behaviors
2. Avoidant
 - a. negative working model of others
 - i. "No one loves me."
 - b. Caregiver's communication patterns:
 - i. Insensitivity to needs
 - ii. Caregiver does not exhibit the caregiver attachment behaviors
 - iii. Children appear detached from their caregiver and disinterested in their caregiver
 - iv. Don't seem to notice or care that their caregiver is not "there" for them
 1. internally they are feeling the need for comfort
3. Anxious-ambivalent
 - a. negative working model of self
 - b. Self concept revolves around doubt, insecurity, and uncertainty
 - i. "I am not lovable."
 - c. Caregiver's communication patterns:
 - i. inconsistent responses
 1. sometimes the caregiver exhibits the caregiver attachment behaviors, but other times does not.
 - ii. parent is often preoccupied or stressed by events in their own life
 1. Relational conflict
 2. Substance abuse
 - d. Children appear clingy, whiny, difficult to console
 - i. Don't know what to expect from caregiver

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Attachment is a life-long process

Attachment styles can change

- Context
- Partners

***What was the name of the experience that Mary Ainsworth conducted to figure out childhood attachment styles

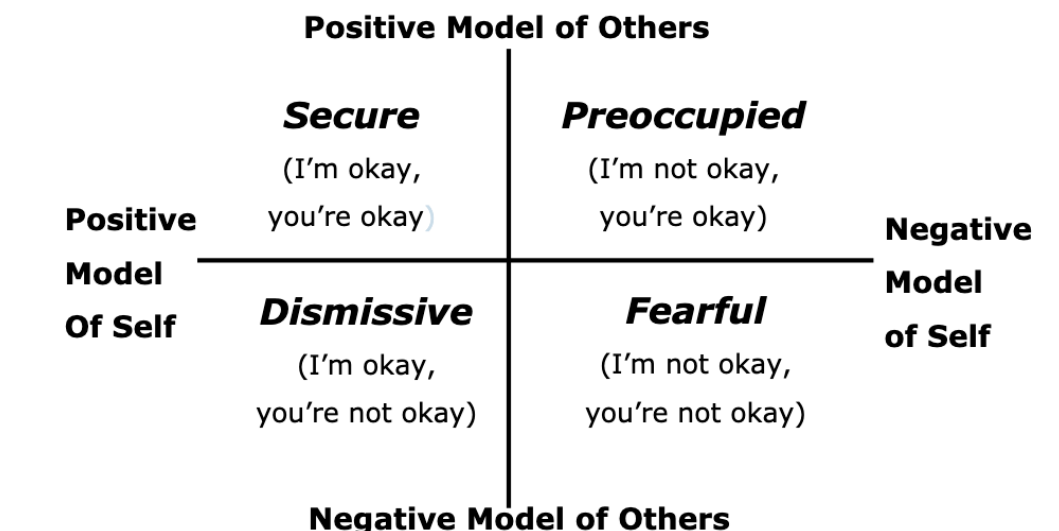
- **Strange Situation**

The Strange Situation

- conducted by Mary Ainsworth
- eight stages, three minutes
- added disorganized category

Bartholomew's 4 Adult Attachment Styles

- Influenced by childhood attachments
 - Same working models
- Adult communication patterns reinforce their attachment style



SECURE: The prosocial style

- Desire a balance between autonomy and closeness
- Are comfortable being single or in a relationship
 - "I'm ok, you're ok."
- Likely to engage in compromise and problem-solving during conflict
- Are likely skilled communicators

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- Disclosures, expression of emotions, etc.
- Reinforcement Effect:
 - Because they are confident and expressive, people react to them positively, reinforcing positive models of self and others

PREOCCUPIED: The emotional style

- Overly involved in relationships and overly dependent on their partners
- “I’m not ok, you’re ok.”
- Want excessive intimacy; worry that partners do not care enough for them
- May view relationships as more important than personal goals and activities
- Highly concerned that a partner will leave them
- Tend to be very (overly?) disclosive
- Tend to be very (overly?) sensitive
- In conflicts, people with a preoccupied attachment often exhibit demanding, nagging behavior and express negative emotion with aggression or passive aggression
- Reinforcement Effect:
 - By escalating intimacy too quickly, they push partners away, thereby reinforcing that they are unworthy of love

FEARFUL: The hesitant style

- Fearful of intimacy
- People with a fearful attachment have often been deeply hurt in the past and have not recovered
- People with a fearful attachment are so concerned about being hurt that they may avoid relationships
- “I’m not ok, you’re not ok.”
- People with a fearful attachment often have trouble expressing emotions and self-disclosing
- People with a fearful attachment don’t usually engage in relationship maintenance behaviors
- View conflict as a threat to a relationship because:
 - Managing conflict often involves disclosure
 - Managing conflict may show interdependence
 - Use withdrawal and defensiveness
- Reinforcement Effect:
 - By avoiding taking risks, they keep themselves from developing the kind of positive relationships that will help them feel better about themselves and others

DISMISSIVE: The detached style

- People with a dismissive attachment style are self-sufficient to the point of pushing others away
- People with a dismissive attachment style may not be interested in relationships because they would rather focus on their own goals and ambitions
- May be uncomfortable with intimacy
- “I’m ok, you’re not ok.”

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- People with a dismissive attachment style are want to prove (to self and others) that they can cope with life on their own
- Dislike relying on others
- Prioritize personal goals and activities over relationships; may think that relationships “hold them back” from achieving their goals
- People with a dismissive attachment style are use low levels of relational maintenance, disclosure, and emotional expression
- In conflicts, they tend to withdraw.
 - Don’t want to show interdependence
 - Don’t want to feel pressured to disclose feelings
- Reinforcement Effect: By learning to get along on their own, they reinforce the idea that they do not need other people to be happy

Preoccupied/Dismissive pairings

- People with a preoccupied attachment style may be drawn to people with a dismissive attachment style
- People with a dismissive attachment style may be drawn to people with a preoccupied attachment style
- Potentially a stressful combination
 - People with a preoccupied attachment likely pursue a great deal (too much?) closeness and reassurance from their partner; may be overly worried that the relationship is going to end
 - may feel like they are “too much” in relationships
 - People with a dismissive attachment style value their space and independence and may feel overwhelmed by what they perceive as neediness from their partner
 - may feel like they “aren’t enough” in relationships
- Why would these two styles pair up?
 - Explanation 1:
 - People with a preoccupied attachment style may be drawn to dismissive partners because they represent a challenge -- an opportunity to attain an emotional connection
 - If it doesn’t work out, it still reinforces their identity of being “too much” in relationships
 - People with a dismissive attachment style may be drawn to preoccupied partners because they reinforce their identity – “compared to my partner, I’m really independent.”
 - Explanation 2:
 - Each partner wants the other’s traits
 - Preoccupied wants to become more independent
 - Dismissive wants to become more relationship-oriented.

Change in attachment styles

Explanations for change in an individual’s attachment style:

1. Significant life/relationship events
 - a. For example, a particularly bitter divorce may prompt a change in attachment style
 - i. i.e., from secure to dismissive

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2. The partner's attachment style
 - a. For example, a secure partner may help a fearful partner become secure.
3. Variability across relationship types
 - a. You may be securely attached in your close friendships, but preoccupied in your romantic relationships

Different types of love

1. Infatuation = passion only
 - a. Probably not long-lasting
2. Empty love = commitment only
 - a. Probably not satisfying
3. Romantic love = passion + intimacy
4. Friendship love = intimacy + commitment
5. Consummate love = passion + intimacy + commitment

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Marston and Hecht's 7 Love Ways

- Another way of understanding love
 - Love is experienced in a variety of way and is communicated to others in a variety of ways
 - Focuses on physiological and behavioral responses to love
 - What physiological changes occur when you are in love?
 - Most common response – people reported feeling more energetic and emotionally intense
 - How do you communicate love to a partner?
 - Most common response – saying “I love you.”
 - How does your partner communicate love to you?
 - Most common response – partner says “I love you.”
1. Collaborative love
 - Love is a *partnership* that involves mutual support and negotiation
 - Love is communicated by enthusiastically supporting one another's goals
 - Love increases energy and intensifies emotion
 2. Active love
 - Love is based on shared interests. It is communicated through engaging in activities together and discussing mutually-interesting topics
 - Love involves feelings of increased strength and increased self-confidence.
 3. Intuitive love
 - Love is a feeling communicated through nonverbal behavior and experienced through physical reactions
 - Love involves feeling warm all over, feeling nervous, feeling butterflies in stomach
 4. Committed love

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- Love is based on commitment and is communicated by planning for the future
 - Involves experiencing strong feelings of connection and spending time together.
- 5. Secure love:
 - Love is based on intimacy and is communicated through intimate self-disclosure
 - Love involves feelings of safety and warmth
- 6. Expressive love
 - Love is shown through overt behavior, such as doing things for the partner
 - Love involves saying “I love you” frequently
- 7. Traditional romantic love
 - Love involves togetherness and commitment
 - Love involves feeling attractive and healthy.

Advice from Martson and Hecht

1. Recognize that your partner’s “love way” may be different from your own
2. Don’t overvalue particular elements of your own “love way.”
3. Focus on, and appreciate, the diverse ways your partner shows love

Biology and Love

Flirting

- Verbal and nonverbal communication behavior with potential sexual or romantic overtones that is goal-oriented
- Nonverbal flirting behaviors are more common than verbal flirting behaviors
 - Especially indirect nonverbal behaviors

Why are indirect nonverbal flirting behaviors most often employed?

- Protect flirter from possible rejection “i was just being friendly”
 - Face preserving
- Also gives the receiver an “out” - meaning they can simply ignore without a verbal rejection
- Nonverbals are important in flirting
 - Facial expression, Posture, Body language, Tone of voice, Appearance, Touch

Why do people flirt?

1. Amusement, to have fun
 - a. Not sexual, may not even be an indicator of attraction
2. To boost self-esteem
 - a. Not sexual, may not even be an indicator of attraction
3. To gauge another’s romantic interest
 - a. “Is this person interested in me romantically?”
4. To reinforce a relationship
 - a. Flirting is an excellent way to maintain interest in a relationship
5. To find a mate

How do people flirt?

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Verbal strategies

1. Compliments
2. Allowing the flirt-ee to talk about her/himself
3. Teasing

Nonverbal strategies

1. Smiling
2. Eye contact
3. Decreasing distance
4. Appropriate touch

5 general styles of flirting

- derived from research
- Strongly related to an individual's personality
- Limited research: only heterosexuals

1. Physical

- People who use this style:
 - are interested in pursuing a sexual relationship with potential partner
 - are highly comfortable and competent communicating sexual interest to a potential partner
 - quickly feel attraction toward a potential partner and act on it

2. Polite

- People who use this style:
 - are highly observant of manners and social rules; often desire a long-term relationship
 - may appear reserved; tend to have fewer partners

3. Playful

- People who use this style:
 - are typically interested in amusement and enhancing self-esteem
 - are not necessarily looking for a sexual partner

4. Sincere

- People who use this style:
 - value emotional connection most in potential partners; often desire a long-term relationship
 - Sexual chemistry is secondary
 - communicate deep interest in the potential partner's life

5. Traditional

- People who use this style:
 - subscribe to traditional gender-specific roles.
 - Men make first move, approach women, lead interaction, and make requests for future engagements
 - Heterosexual

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General Orientations Toward Sex

1. Procreational
 - a. sex is for reproduction
2. Recreational
 - a. sex is for enjoyment and pleasure
3. Relational
 - a. sex is an expression of intimacy

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Chapter 9

Communicating Sexually

Sex in short-term relationships

Hook ups

- Motivated by sexual desire, sexual experimentation, physical pleasure, alcohol or drug use
 - Most research indicates that alcohol use is involved in the majority of hookups
- If hookups are consensual, most research suggest they do not lead to negative long term psychological consequences
- Hook ups are increasingly considered a normative form of identity exploration for emerging adults
- Both men and women seek hooks
 - Though women report fewer positive feelings about hooking up than a man
 - In the short term
- Don't always involve intercourse
 - Definitions of hooking up can vary considerably

**condom use is highest in first year of university, this might be because of uncertainty

Sex in relationships

- Couples with high levels of sexual satisfaction also report high levels of love, connection, excitement, and relational satisfaction
- Direct verbal, partner-to-partner instrumental communication about sex increases relational satisfaction
 - Instrumental communication = messages aimed at accomplishing a task
 - Need to listen to partner
- Indirect communication about sex is not effective in increasing relational satisfaction
 - Hinting is not effective

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****The best way to improve sexual satisfaction is direct partner to partner instrumental communication**

- this therefore improves relational satisfaction
- sex is good for relationships

Communication and safer sex

What are barriers to safer sex communication?

1. The “truth” bias
 - a. We tend to believe the people we like
 - b. STI status
 - c. STI testing
 - d. Monogamy
2. Not wanting to be seen as promiscuous or suggesting the partner is promiscuous
 - a. Example: “if i want to use a condom, my partner might think i'm a slut”
3. Not wanting to ruin the “moment”
 - a. Idea that talking about safer sex is not sexy
 - b. Idea that putting on a condom will be interruptive
4. Not wanting to convey distrust or hurt a partner's feelings
 - a. Example: “If I want to use a condom, will my partner think it is because I think he / she is dirty?”

Best Communication strategies for safer sex

1. Discuss pregnancy prevention (if applicable)
2. Discuss prevention of STIs
 - Condoms (if applicable) and other safer sex practices
3. Negotiate monogamy
 - Exclusive or nonexclusive?

Interdependence theory

- Interdependence theory = human relationships involve the exchange of rewards and costs
- *Rewards* = exchanged resources that are pleasurable and gratifying
- *Costs* = exchanged resources that result in loss or punishment

Types of rewards & costs

1. Emotional - positive and negative feelings experienced in a relationship
 - a. Reward = positive feeling
 - b. Cost = negative feeling (anxious, stressed)
2. Social - involves social appearance and the ability to interact in social environments
 - a. Reward = partner makes you appear socially desirable to others and/or the enjoyable social situations that come with being in a relationship with the partner
 - b. Costs = partner makes you appear socially undesirable to others and/or the enjoyable social situations that come with being in a relationship with the partner
3. Instrumental - the activities and or tasks in the relationship
 - a. Reward = partner is proficient in handling a task

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- b. Cost = partner causes unnecessary work or the partner impedes the other's progress in a task
- 4. Opportunity = chances an individual gains or gives up as a consequence of being in a relationship
 - a. Reward = gains that a person is able to receive in their relationship that would not ordinarily receive
 - b. Cost = losses that a person would not have if they were not in a relationship

Reward and Costs

Outcomes = rewards - cost

- People weigh rewards and costs differently
 - Positive outcome - rewards outnumber costs
 - Negative outcome - cost outnumber rewards
- Positive outcomes are not enough to keep a relationship going

We evaluate outcomes based on..

1. Comparison level
 - predicts satisfaction
 - What kind of outcomes are we expecting from the relationship?
 - Likely based in part on our past relationship
 - How do outcomes compare to our expectations?
 - “Just ok” positive outcomes vs. “really good” positive outcomes
 - If outcomes exceed comparison level expectation = satisfaction → Outcomes exceed expectations = happy about relationships
2. Comparison level for alternatives
 - predicts dependence on relationships
 - Perception of outcomes if you were to leave the relationship and move to the best alternative situation you think is available to you
 - Could I do better with someone else?
 - Would I be happier if I was single?
 - If you perceive that you would be better off with another partner or single, you might consider leaving your current relationship even if the current relationship is satisfying
 - If you perceive that there are not better options to you, you might stay in a relationship even if its satisfying

Come into play when evaluating outcomes

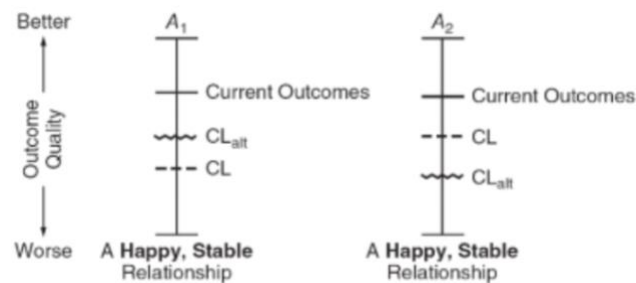
- Investments
 - What would you lose if the relationship were to end? How important are these investments to you?
 - example: rich father staying with mom to not give her 1/2 wealth
- Self esteem
 - Impacts how people think about comparison for alternatives
- Access to information
 - How much do you really know about comparisons for alternatives?

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Four types of relationships

1. A happy, stable relationship

- a. Current outcomes exceed comparison level for alternatives and comparison level.



2. An unhappy, stable relationship

- a. Current outcomes are lower than comparison level but higher than comparison level for alternatives
- i. Stable, so unlikely to leave
1. Alternatives not appealing



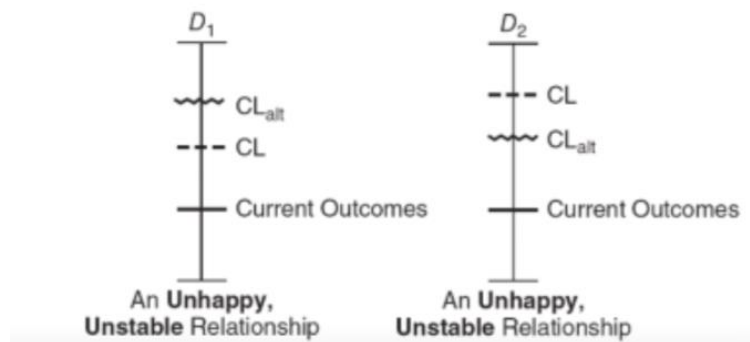
3. A happy, unstable relationship

- a. Current outcomes are above comparison level but below comparison level for alternatives
- i. Unstable – you think you could do better and may consider leaving the relationship

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4. An unhappy, unstable relationship
- Current outcomes are lower than comparison level and comparison level for alternatives.



Comparison level considerations

- An individual's comparison level may rise over time, so a previously rewarding relationship may seem less rewarding
 - Expectations have risen
- Sociocultural relationships
 - People expect more out of their relationships than they did a generation ago

Comparison level for alternatives considerations

- Cultural changes
 - More women in the workforce
 - Increased mobility
 - Dating apps / internet
 - Divorce less taboo

Why are there so many unhappy relationships?

1. Failure to notice positive behaviors performed by their partners
 - a. Up to 25% of positive behaviors might not be noticed
2. Attachment style
3. Preference for different prosocial maintenance behavior

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*** we are really good at engaging in prosocial maintenance behaviors at the beginning of a relationship, we are less good as the relationship matures

Takeaways?

1. Relationships take consistent effort
2. Interdependence mangieri's conflict
3. Intimacy makes people feel vulnerable
4. Relationships involve unwelcome surprises
5. Unrealistic expectations can undermine relationships

Maintaining relationships

How do romantic couples keep their relationships going?

- Relationship maintenance

Prosocial maintenance behaviors

- Positive behaviors, used over the course of a relationship, that promote closeness, trust, and liking
- Promote liking, loving, and commitment
- Romantic couples that use pro-social strategies often have merged identities, which helps them share resources and work together
- Romantic couples who are most satisfied with their relationships regularly use pro-social maintenance behaviors

Types of prosocial maintenance behaviors

1. Positivity
 - a. Making an effort to make daily interactions with the partner pleasant and enjoyable, even when you might be distracted or stressed by events outside of the relationship
 - i. Compliments
 - ii. Politeness
 - iii. Cheerfulness
2. Openness:
 - a. Self-disclosure, sharing secrets, routine talk, listening
 - i. Keeping up-to-date on what the partner is doing in his/her life
 - ii. Communicating interest in the partner's life
 - iii. "Tell me all about your day."
3. Assurances:
 - a. Giving partner assurances about commitment to the relationship
 - b. Giving partner assurances that the relationship is going well.
 - c. Giving partner assurances that you find him/her attractive.
4. Social Networking:
 - a. Spending time with the partner's social network
 - i. Friends
 - ii. Family

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- iii. Work functions
- 5. Task Sharing:
 - a. Performing routine tasks and chores with the partner
 - i. Walking the dog together
 - ii. Grocery shopping together
 - iii. Cooking together.
- 6. Joint activities:
 - a. Engaging in “special” activities and spending time with the partner.
 - i. “Date night”
 - ii. Vacations with the partner
 - iii. Day trips with the partner.
- 7. Romance and affection:
 - a. Communicating romantic feelings for the partner.
 - i. Displaying affection for the partner
 - ii. Flirting with the partner
 - iii. Sex with the partner
- 8. Humor:
 - a. Using inside jokes and other forms of humor when interacting with the partner

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Chapter 10

Maintaining Relationships

Antisocial maintenance behaviors

- Behaviors that discourasge interaction
- Behaviors that try to control or manipulate a partner
- Behaviors that attempt to change a partner

- The use of some anti-social maintenance behaviors is not necessarily bad for relationships
 - If used infrequently
- Trying to keep the relationship going by NOT interacting with your partner

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

1. Avoidance:
 - Attempting to keep a relationship going by:
 - Evading the partner in certain situations or on certain issues
 - Avoiding conflict or disagreement
 - May be helpful in some instances
 - “We are never going to agree on X, so we won’t talk about it.”
 - If it becomes and pattern or a themes, might be a sign that things aren’t going great
2. Jealousy induction:
 - Attempting to keep a relationship going by making a partner jealous
 - The goal is to redirect a partner’s attention back to the relationship

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- Can easily backfire
 - Jealousy induction tends to be associated with fear that a partner is romantically interested in a third party
 - People who employ jealousy induction often hope to create feelings of love and possessiveness in their partners
 - Thus prompting a desire to remain actively engaged in the relationship
 - Examples of jealousy induction include:
 - purposely flirting with a potential rival in front of the partner.
 - commenting on the attractiveness of others in front of the partner.
 - talking about rivals in front of a partner
 - fine line
3. Spying:
- Attempting to keep a relationship going by gaining information about your partner without their knowledge
 - "Keeping tabs" on a partner to make sure they are still invested in the relationship
 - Online, in person
 - Spying is usually about wanting to control a partner; suggests a lack of trust
4. Communicative Infidelity:
- Engaging in sexual activity with someone else to send a message to the partner
 - "Teach a partner a lesson."
 - Could be a means of revenge
 - Could be a bid for attention
5. Allowing control:
- Attempting to keep a relationship going by focusing exclusively on the partner
 - Ignoring friends and family
 - Letting partner make all decisions
6. Destructive conflict:
- Attempting to keep a relationship going by trying to control the partner using aggression
 - Yelling at partner
 - Abusing partner
 - Starting arguments with partner so you can tell her/him what to do

Maintenance in **long-distance (LD) relationships**

- Researchers estimate that 25% to 40% of college students' romantic relationships are long-distance
- Because partners are not face-to-face, they engage in fewer prosocial maintenance behaviors
 - E.g., task sharing, joint activities, social networking
- **really popular in college student population

Why do people find LD relationships satisfying?

1. partners can control the communication
 - E.g., timing of communication
2. partners are often on their "best behavior" when together

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- Special activities
- 3. Partner idealization
 - A person attributes exaggeratedly positive qualities to their partner
 - Note: some idealization is healthy in a relationship
 - Positive illusions
 - Sometimes unrealistic and unattainable

It is not uncommon for LD relationships terminate when they become proximal and idealization fades

- Can't live up to idealized expectations

{In-class video}

Signs you might not be ready for a long distance relationship

1. You rely on physical intimacy to feel close
2. You are already facing communication problems
3. You haven't had the difficult conversations yet
4. You get jealous easily
5. You have second thoughts on your relationship

Brain research and relationship maintenance

- How do you sustain feelings of romantic love in long-term relationships?
- What are long-term couples good at, according to brain research?

Sustain the three basic systems

1. Have regular sex
 - a. driving up testosterone
 - b. cuddling- drive up oxytocin
 - c. drive up dopamine- sustain romantic love
2. Do novel things together
 - a. Feelings of romantic love
 - b. sustains feelings of intense romantic love
3. Maintain physical attachment
 - a. Stay in touch
 - b. sleep in their arms
 - c. hold hands

Three brain regions - skills that long term couples have

1. Practicing empathy
2. Controlling your own emotions
3. Positive illusions
 - a. overlook what you don't like, focus on what you do
 - b. say 5 nice things a day
 - i. reduces their cortisol and immune system

Strategic vs. routine maintenance

Strategic maintenance behaviors

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- intentionally designed to maintain a relationship
- Doing something special for your partner on his/her birthday
- Doing something special for your partner to apologize after a fight

Routine maintenance behaviors

- are used without the express purpose of maintaining the relationship
- However, they help couples preserve their bonds with one another
 - Task sharing: e.g., preparing everyday meals together
 - Positivity: e.g., expressing happiness when your partner gets home from school or work
- Routine maintenance is likely more important than strategic maintenance in maintaining close relationships
- Consistently communicates commitment, closeness, and liking

Equity theory

- Focuses on determining whether the distribution of resources in a relationship is fair to both relational partners
- Predicts that people are most satisfied with a relationship when the ratio between benefits and contributions is similar for both partners
 - They are not getting a “worse deal” than their partner
- Partners do not have to receive equal benefits or make equal contributions as long as the ratio between these benefits and contributions is similar
- Benefits include
 - love, care, and financial security
- Contributions include
 - effort, time, and financial resources

Principles of Equity Theory

1. Individuals try to maximize the benefits they obtain from a relationship
2. People in satisfying relationships develop rules for distributing resources fairly
3. Inequitable relationships often lead to distress
 - a. This distress prompts individuals to restore equity
 - i. The more distress an individual experiences, the harder he or she will try to alleviate the distress
4. Individuals in equitable relationships experience more satisfaction
 - a. also use more prosocial maintenance behaviors than individuals in inequitable relationships

Consequences of (In)Equity

- Equity is related to:
 - Feelings of happiness, satisfaction, fairness, and appreciation
 - more positivity, openness, and assurances; and more constructive expression of negative emotions
- Over Benefited inequity is related to:
 - (the person who is over benefited)

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- feelings of guilt (sometimes)
- tendency to use fewer prosocial maintenance behaviors
 - because they probably like the status quo of benefitting more

Dealing with distress in inequitable relationships

People can relieve their distress by:

1. restoring actual equity
2. restoring psychological equity
 - “I guess I’m not under-benefitted after all.”
 - General equity vs. specific equity.
3. leaving the relationship

What is conflict?

Interpersonal conflict occurs in interactions where there are real or perceived incompatible goals, scarce resources, or opposing viewpoints

Common conflict issues in married couples

1. Household chores
2. Money
3. Jealousy
4. Sex
5. Children

Frequency of conflict in romantic relationships

- Most romantic couples have between 1 and 3 small disagreements per week, and 1 or 2 serious disagreements per month
- Some level of conflict is normal and healthy in close relationships.
 - A total lack of conflict suggests that one partner is being too passive
- The way people manage conflict is more important than the frequency of conflict

Gottman’s Five couple types

- Couples are classified by how they handle conflict in their relationships
- Whether a relationship lasts largely depends on how conflicts are managed

** Couple types are based on how the people in the couple handle their conflicts

- 3 healthy couple types
- 2 couple types associated with divorce

Five couple types

1. Validating couples
 - Put a great deal of emphasis on supporting and understanding their partner’s point of view
 - Empathetic
 - Tend to agree on issues such as sex, money, religion, and children
 - When disagreements occur, they work out compromises

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- Disagreements are calm and measured
 - No shouting
 - No “below the belt” comments
- 2. Volatile couples
 - Couple is comfortable with disagreement and lack of harmony
 - Communication style is emotionally expressive
 - Enjoy debate
 - Disagreements are settled through argument and discussion
 - Conflict tends to be productive and energizes the relationship
 - Communication is usually characterized by laughter, shared amusement, and humor
- 3. Conflict avoidant couples
 - Do not like conflict
 - Not emotionally expressive
 - Emphasize common ground
 - Partners placate and please each other rather than meet their own needs
 - Often walk away from arguments
 - Achieve a clear balance between independence and interdependence
 - This couple type is most likely to have separate friends and interests
 - But are also usually very connected when they engage in mutual interests
- 4. Hostile/engaged couples
 - Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way
 - Both partners are highly defensive
 - Frequent use of insults, sarcasm, and personal criticisms
- 5. Hostile/disengaged couples
 - Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way
 - During conflict, unable or unwilling to see the other person’s perspective
 - Partners do not listen to one another
 - Emotional disengagement from the partner and the relationship
 - extremely likely to divorce

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2/28/2024

Chapter 11

Conflict in Relationships

Six conflict styles

The conflict style individuals use is often intergenerational.

- We tend to use the conflict styles we saw our parents use
- Conflict styles are based on two dimensions:
 1. Degree of directness
 - a. the extent to which individuals talk directly about issues, express their opinions, and pursue their goals

{Exam 3 Material}

2. Degree of cooperativeness
 - a. the extent to which individuals consider the needs and perspectives of their partner.
1. Competitive fighting
 - Direct, aggressive, hostile, and uncooperative.
 - Competing to defeat the partner/win the argument
 - Win-lose orientation (I win, you lose)
 - “Win” is only temporary
 - Usually associated with poor communication competence and relational dissatisfaction
 - Specific tactics include:
 - personal criticism
 - blaming or accusations
 - hostile questioning and teasing
 - presumptive attribution
 - demands and threats
2. Compromising
 - Direct, moderately cooperative
 - Part-win, part lose orientation
 - Each partner gives up something
 - Quality of compromise varies based on how mutually acceptable the outcome is
 - Is the compromise fair to all parties?
 - Specific tactics include:
 - taking the middle ground
 - alternating
 - appealing to fairness
3. Collaborating
 - Direct and cooperative
 - Win-win orientation
 - Creative problem solving to satisfy both partners’ needs.
 - Solution-oriented
 - Most effective
 - Specific tactics include:
 - Inquiring about the partner’s feelings
 - Communicating support and empathy
 - Accepting responsibility
 - Emphasizing commonalities
 - Initiating problem-solving and brainstorming
4. Indirect fighting
 - Indirect, uncooperative, and hostile
 - Passive aggressive strategies
 - Focus on dismissing the partner’s position and shutting down conversation in an effort not to lose the argument
 - Specific tactics include:
 - ignoring the partner or giving the silent treatment

{Exam 3 Material}

- cold or dirty looks
- rolling one's eyes
- sarcasm and contemptuous looks

5. Avoiding

- Indirect, neutral cooperation
- Sometimes leads to a lose-lose situation with issues left unresolved
- However, in some cases, avoiding is beneficial
 - Preferable to aggression
 - Choosing to avoid vs. feeling silenced
 - Topical; "agree to disagree."
- Specific tactics include:
 - denying the conflict exists
 - being indirect and evasive about the conflict
 - changing topics

6. Yielding

- Cooperative, indirect
- Lose-win orientation (I lose, you win)
- Problematic if one person always gives in (the chilling effect)
- Beneficial if the conflict issue is more important to one partner than the other
- Specific tactics include:
 - appeasement (giving in)
 - smoothing over differences
 - passive acceptance of alternative positions

Conflict styles

Why do couples use hostile conflict styles more often than other, more positive conflict styles?

- *Hostile styles* = competitive fighting and indirect fighting
- One explanation is the principle of negative reciprocity

The principle of negative reciprocity

Aggression creates more aggression

- Aggressive and hostile behaviors are returned
- The problem with negative reciprocity is that a small thing quickly becomes a big thing
- There are at least three problems related to negative reciprocity

1. Gunnysacking

- *Gunnysacking* = storing up past grievances and dumping them (all at once) on a partner during a conflict
- Because multiple attacks are involved, partners feel defensive and overwhelmed
 - And probably unable to discuss an issue productively

2. Kitchen-sinking

- *Kitchen-sinking* = rehashing old arguments during a conflict
- same as gunnysacking with the multiple attacks

{Exam 3 Material}

3. Bringing other people into the conflict

- Promotes feelings of defensiveness, which make problem resolution very difficult
- Mentioning negative things other people have said about the partner
- Saying negative things about the partner's friends or family
- Comparing partner to former partners
- NR is a common pattern and can predict relationship dissatisfaction
- For satisfying relationships, positive interactions should greatly outnumber negative interactions
 - Ratio of 5: 1 (Five positive to one negative)
- Why do couples use hostile conflict styles more often than other, more positive conflict styles?
- Hostile styles = competitive fighting and indirect fighting
- Another explanation is the demand-withdraw pattern

Demand-withdraw

One person wants to engage in discussion of an issue (the demander) and the other wants to avoid or end discussion (the withdrawer)

- Works "both ways"
- More demands create more withdrawing
- More withdrawing creates more demands
- Demander uses highly charged emotional requests, criticism, complaints
- Withdrawer uses defensiveness and passive inaction
- Why does the D-W pattern happen?
 - Often a result of "saving up" complaints over a period of time
 - Can be a symptom of an inequitable relationships (the demander is trying to obtain more power)
 - Intergenerational effects
 - Unresolved tension between connection – autonomy
- 4 manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern
 1. Discuss/exit
 - One partner seeks discussion of an issue; the other partner exits physically or communicatively
 2. Perfunctory response
 - One partner asks a series of questions; the other gives inauthentic responses
 - Partner A: Will you take care of the cat's box?
 - Partner B: Yes.
 - Partner A: When will you do it?
 - Partner B: Later.
 - Partner A: What does that mean?
 - Partner B: I don't know, later.
 - Partner A: I need you to tell me.
 - Partner B: Ok
 3. Complain/deny

{Exam 3 Material}

- One partner complains about an issue; the other partner denies the legitimacy of the issue
 - Partner A: Did you take care of the cat's box like you said you would?
 - Partner B: I don't know why you keep bringing this up. It's not a big deal
- 4. Criticize/Defend
 - Another version of demand/withdraw
 - Partner turns it around
 - Partner A: You are being disrespectful about the cat's box
 - Partner B: I'm not being disrespectful -- you are, by bringing it up all the time

20.5

2/29/2024

Conflict in Relationships

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Model for understanding how conflict can negatively impact relationships

- "A relationship is probably going to end if we see the four horseman"
- 90% accurately predicted divorce within 5 years
- Developed, tested, and extensively researched by Dr. John Gottman and his wife, Dr. Julie Gottman

Couples who end up divorcing exhibit conflict patterns that include these **four** components

1. Criticism

- Criticism = Complaint + negative words about partner's character or personality
- "Why are you so selfish? I always have to take care of the cat's litter box. You really just don't care."
- Complaint = addresses a specific action at which your partner failed.
 - More productive than criticism.
 - "I'm upset that you didn't take care of the cat's litter box last night. We agreed it was your turn."

2. Contempt/disgust

- With partner as a "whole person"
- Fueled by long-standing problems in a relationship
- Suggests superiority ("I'm better than you.")
- Contempt/disgust might involve:
 - Hostile humor
 - Name calling
 - Mockery
 - Insult
 - Sarcasm
 - Eye rolling
 - "You're crazy."
 - "You can't do anything right."
- Contempt/disgust with partner is very stressful

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- Couples that are contemptuous of each other are more likely to suffer from infectious illness (colds, the flu, etc.) than others
 - their immune systems weaken
- 3. Defensiveness
 - Occurs when people feel the need to protect themselves from personal attacks
 - Problem does not get resolved – “It’s not me, it’s you.”
 - Defensive behaviors include:
 - denying responsibility
 - issuing counter-complaints
 - making excuses
 - making accusations to deflect responsibility
 - Partner A : “Did you text Laura and Steve to let them know that we’re not coming tonight, like you promised this morning?”
 - Partner B: “I was too busy today! As a matter of fact you know just how busy my schedule was. Why didn’t you just do it? Why do I have to do everything?”
- 4. Stonewalling
 - Occurs after chronic criticism, contempt, and defensiveness.
 - Partners “turn to stone” – they disengage, stop communicating, and see continued *interactions as futile*

Short term stress vs. chronic stress

- Chronic stress prompts the release of cortisol, epinephrine, norepinephrine from the adrenal gland and can lead to:
 - Hypertension
 - Cholesterol plaque build up
 - IBS
 - Weight gain
 - Weakened immune system
- Coping with stress:
 1. Change relationship
 2. Terminate relationship
 3. Exercise
 4. Meditation

Emotional flooding

- During a conflict, negative emotions become so overwhelming that cognition is impaired
 - And people may say things they don’t really mean and/or regret later
 - When someone is experiencing emotional flooding, it takes about 20 minutes for their brain to return to its normal state
- Takes 20 minutes for your brain to calm back down
- What happens during emotional flooding?
 - Psychological arousal (increased heart rate and blood pressure)
 - Difficulty processing information
 - Difficulty thinking clearly
- Brain becomes overwhelmed with cortisol, epinephrine (adrenaline), and norepinephrine
 - Brain flooded with stress hormones
 - Prefrontal cortex shuts down

{Exam 3 Material}

- Rational thinking shuts down – fight or flight

Attribution Theory

- Provides insight into predicting which conflict style a couple will use
- People have a need to determine the cause of others relationships
- Individuals have a fundamental need to determine the cause of others' behaviors
 - Especially in conflict

Three key questions

1. Personal vs. situational
 - Is the cause of this conflict a personality flaw (personal) or is the cause of the conflict due to the circumstances we are in (situational)?
 - They're a shitty partner vs they're having a tough time at work
 2. Unstable vs. stable
 - Is this behavior that is making me upset atypical (unstable) or typical (stable)
 - They're usually pretty good at doing chores vs they do this all the time
 3. Global vs. specific
 - Is the behavior that is making me mad apparent elsewhere (global) or does it just apply to this particular situation (specific)?
- Situational + unstable + specific attributions tend to predict the use of more positive conflict styles
 - Collaborating and compromising
 - Personal + stable + global attributions tend to predict more negative conflict styles
 - Competitive fighting, indirect fighting

Accommodation

- responding to a partner's destructive act by inhibiting the impulse to reciprocate with another destructive act
 - Resisting negative reciprocity
 - aggression creates more aggression! break the cycle!
 - This helps to defuse a negative situation

Children and relationship satisfaction/conflict

- When a couple has children, relationship satisfaction declines and conflict increases (Doss et al., 2009)
- In most cases, parenthood does not bring people closer (Hansen, 2012)
- Parenthood changes how couples interact (Johnson, 2016)
 - Communication becomes more business-like

Guidelines for handling conflict

- research-backed
1. Be aware of confirmation bias

{Exam 3 Material}

- *Confirmation bias* = when you gather evidence that reinforces your beliefs and disregard evidence that challenges your beliefs
- 2. Think about attributions
 - We have a tendency to base our own mistakes on a particular situation, but we often base our partner's mistakes on a character deficiency
 - "If I'm treating you poorly, it's because I had a bad day. If you're treating me poorly, it's because you're bad at relationships"
- 3. Avoid "never" and "always."
 - "You never do the dishes."
- 4. One conflict issue at a time.
- 5. Focus on behaviors, not character
- 6. Switch from reacting to reflecting.
 - When you're having a conflict try telling the person you're speaking with what you heard them say
 - In conflict, people often stop listening because they are planning their rebuttal
 - "What I'm hearing you say is that when I do this at these moments, you feel X."
 - Gottman's XYZ strategy
 - When you do X in situation Y, I feel Z

{Exam 3 Material}

** MOSTLY end of Exam 3 Material (but some crucial material for Exam 3 may be found beyond this point)

21.7

3/11/2024

Chapter 12

When Relational Partners Disagree

Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Solvable problems

- refer to issues or conflicts in a relationship that, with effective communication and problem-solving skills, can be resolved to the satisfaction of both partners
- These problems tend to be specific, concrete, and often related to day-to-day matters
- They may involve issues like household chores, financial decisions, or time management
- Resolution of solvable problems
 - Couples can work together to find compromises, make specific plans, or establish clear agreements to address solvable problems. This may involve brainstorming solutions, evaluating options, and reaching a mutually acceptable resolution.
- Examples of solvable problems might include disagreements over how to divide household responsibilities, how to manage finances, or how to coordinate schedules.

Unsolvable problems

- refer to issues or conflicts in a relationship that, due to fundamental differences in values, personality traits, or deeply ingrained preferences, may not have a clear, mutually satisfying resolution
- These problems tend to be more enduring and related to core aspects of each partner's identity, beliefs, or desires. They may involve differences in life goals, values, or personality traits
- Management and coping of unsolvable problems
 - Rather than seeking a solution, couples must learn to manage and cope with unsolvable problems. This may involve accepting differences, finding ways to support each other, and developing strategies to minimize conflict around these issues
 - Examples of unsolvable problems might include differences in religious beliefs, fundamental values, or differing desires regarding having children

Understanding the distinction between solvable and unsolvable problems can be crucial for couples

- It allows them to prioritize their efforts, focusing on effective resolution strategies for solvable issues, while learning to navigate and accept differences in unsolvable areas
- This can lead to increased mutual understanding, improved communication, and a more harmonious relationship overall
- Recognizing the nature of certain issues can reduce frustration and tension within the relationship

{Exam 3 Material}

Science of love

{In-class video}

- Commitment
- Trust
- Calm

Power

- Definition: An individual's ability to influence others
- Powerful = able to influence others
- Relationships tend to be most satisfying when power is evenly distributed between partners
- Partners influence each other

Enabling power – using expressive, composed behavior to influence others

- Involves the ability to communicate self-confidence and competence
- Uses interpersonal relationships to assist in achieving goals (“we’ve been good friends for such a long time, so you know how important this is to me”)
- People who use enabling power tend to be successful in achieving their goals and maintaining good relationships, especially over the long term

Disabling power – using intimidation, threats, punishments, and other harsh tactics to influence others

- The use of disabling power may be effective in the short term, but is not typically effective in the long term
- Using disabling power tends to result in hurt feelings, resistance, resentment, and dissatisfaction

Five power principles

- Power dynamics in close relationships can be conceptualized in terms of five principles
 - Power is dynamic
 - Power principles illustrate the importance of egalitarian relationships.
1. Power as a perception
 - Others are only powerful to the extent to which we think they are powerful.
 - Do we believe that the person has the ability to influence others?
 2. Power as a relational concept
 - Power exists in all relationships
 - People are most happy in equalitarian relationships
 - Though most romantic relationships involve small power imbalances
 - However, power is dynamic.
 3. Power as resource based
 - More resources = more power (ability to influence others).
 - Traditionally conceptualized in terms of money. This narrow conceptualization has been criticized
 - Parenting ability, physical attractiveness, communication skill, sexual rewards

The scarcity hypothesis

- People have the most power when the resources they possess are hard to come by or in high demand
4. Power as having less to lose

{Exam 3 Material}

- In a relationship, the person with less to lose has a greater amount of power

Dependence power:

- People who are dependent on their relationships and have low quality alternatives are in a powerless position

Principle of least interest

- the person who is more attracted and/or more in love has less power

5. Power as a prerogative:

- the partner with more power can make and break the rules

Enacting power

- In everyday situations, people use a variety of power tactics to prompt people into particular action

Power tactics can be classified according to two dimensions:

- the extent to which they are direct or indirect
 - the extent to which they are unilateral or bilateral
1. Direct – indirect
 - Direct tactics
 - Using unambiguous communication to influence others
 - Asking (“I ask for what I want”)
 - Persistence (“I repeatedly remind her of what I want until she gives in”)
 - Indirect tactics
 - Using ambiguous communication to influence others. Indirect tactics include:
 - Suggesting (“I drop hints and subtly suggest what I want”)
 - Positive affect (“I try to get what I want through being affectionate”)
 - Use of negative affect (“I pout or cry to get what I want”).
 2. Unilateral – bilateral
 - Unilateral tactics
 - Taking independent action to influence others. Unilateral strategies include:
 - telling (“I tell him what I want”)
 - withdrawing (“I stop talking to her until she does what I want”)
 - Bilateral tactics
 - Using interactive strategies to influence others. Bilateral strategies include:
 - persuasion (“I engage him in conversation to try to persuade him that my way is right”)
 - bargaining (“We negotiate something that is agreeable to both of us; we try to compromise”)
 - reasoning (“I engage her in conversation and I try to argue my position logically”).

Direct and bilateral strategies are most often associated with:

- Relationship satisfaction

{Exam 3 Material}

- Egalitarian relationships

3/13

22.5 - Dominance and Power plays in relationships

Self-Determination Theory (SDT)

- a theory of motivation and personality that focuses on understanding the factors that drive human behavior and lead to personal growth, well-being, and fulfillment
- SDT proposes that there are three fundamental psychological needs that are essential for human well-being and optimal functioning:
 1. Autonomy:
 - The need to feel in control of one's own actions and decisions, rather than feeling controlled by external forces
 2. Competence:
 - The need to feel capable and effective in one's pursuits and endeavors
 3. Relatedness:
 - The need for meaningful connections, relationships, and a sense of belonging with others

In relationships, individuals may be motivated to interact with their partners because of:

- Intrinsic Motivation:
 - Engaging in activities or behaviors within the relationship because they are personally meaningful, enjoyable, or aligned with one's values and desires
- Extrinsic Motivation:
 - Engaging in activities to gain rewards, approval, or to avoid conflict or negative consequences.'
- Amotivation:
 - A lack of motivation or interest in the relationship, which can lead to disengagement and apathy

SDT emphasizes the importance of fostering intrinsic motivation in relationships.

- When individuals feel autonomously motivated to engage with their partner, they are more likely to experience a deeper sense of connection, satisfaction, and fulfillment

A relationship environment that supports autonomy, competence, and relatedness is more likely to nurture intrinsic motivation and foster overall well-being

- Controlling or coercive behaviors, on the other hand, can undermine these basic psychological needs

When individuals experience autonomy, competence, and relatedness within their relationships, they are more likely to report higher levels of relationship satisfaction, intimacy, and overall well-being

SDT suggests that individuals in healthy relationships are able to balance their need for autonomy with a desire for emotional closeness and connection

- This involves respecting each other's independence while also nurturing the bonds of the relationship

{Exam 3 Material}

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

- Parents need power over children, especially when they are young

5 general parenting styles

1. Authoritarian:

demanding and nonresponsive (the dictator)

- Allow for little open dialogue between parent and child and expect children to follow a very strict set of rules and expectations
- Usually rely on harsh punishment to demand obedience or teach a lesson

2. Permissive:

undemanding and responsive (often called “indulgent” parenting)

- Parent avoids confrontation
- Few rules for child’s behavior and general lack of structure
- More interested in a “friend” relationship than a parental relationship with child
- May attempt to bribe child with large rewards

3. Authoritative:

demanding and responsive (the mentor)

- Parents have high expectations for their children, but temper these expectations with understanding and support
- Structure for child’s life (e.g., consistent bedtime, household rules)
- Clear expectations for child’s behavior
- Open communication between parent and child

4. Neglectful:

Not responsive, not demanding (often called “absent parenting”)

- Uninvolved in the child’s life
- Provides very little guidance
- Provides very little support
- Indifferent to child’s needs

5. Over-involved:

- Makes almost all decisions for the child
- Over-schedules child
- Is hesitant to let child make mistakes (and learn from their mistakes)

- Authoritative parenting is generally believed to create the healthiest environment for a child and fosters a positive relationship between parent and child

{In-class video}

What are the effects of each parent's styles?

- Authoritarian
 - suppressing emotions and following duties
 - becomes obedient but doesn't know what she really wants
- Permissive
 - doesn't know his limits
 - bad loser
 - does not consider others

{Exam 3 Material}

- Authoritative
 - learns that some things are difficult but develops strength to endure hardships
 - expresses own opinions in appropriate manner
 - agrees to rules after they have been discussed and he understands them
- Neglectful
 - it doesn't matter what she does because no one cares anyway
 - lack of trust in herself and others
 - negative image of herself
 - tries not to feel anything at all
- Over-involved
 - 'snowplows' 'helicopter parents'
 - protest when anything requires any effort

Separation and individuation:

- a transition point during which teenagers distance themselves from parents
- power struggles and increased conflict between parents and children
 - Quality of communication between parents and adolescents typically decreases for a period of time and then recovers
 - Level of closeness between parents and adolescents may also decrease for a period of time
 - The character of the recovered communication (after separation and individuation) is more adult-like
 - power dynamic is realigned
- More reliance on peers
 - Peers may become more influential than parents for a period of time
- A renegotiation of rules and privacy boundaries
 - To reflect the child's age and maturity
 - parent-adolescent conflict is normal.
 - necessary realignments of relationship roles
 - this constructive process is most likely to occur when conflicts are neither extreme nor persistent and
 - when they arise in a relationship characterized by warmth and closeness

{In-class video}

The teenage brain

- Importance of sleep
 - Growth hormones
 - Delayed release of melatonin in teens
- When does the brain stop developing?
 - Prefrontal cortex
 - **not fully developed until mid 20s
 - last to be fully shaped
 - Nucleus Accumbens
 - pleasure and reward center
 - develops fairly early on

{Exam 3 Material}

- brain develops from back of the brain to front of their brain
- Why is it important to LEARN in the teenage years?
 - Synaptic pruning
 - use it or lose it phase

****Girls brains develop faster than boy brains**

Power in marriage

“Traditional” marriages

- one partner makes most decisions; roles are highly specified
 - in heterosexual marriages, by gender
- Power is imbalanced (one partner has most of the power)

Egalitarian marriages

- “peer marriages”
 - true partnerships
 - based on joint decision making
 - shared responsibility for finances and household tasks
 - power much more evenly distributed
 - use of direct requests and bargaining as a verbal influence strategies
 - use of compromise and collaboration as conflict styles
- Although some people are happy in “traditional” marriages, research shows that egalitarian marriages seem to offer the best chance for intimacy and happiness

Transgressions

Relational transgressions

- occur when individuals break implicit or explicit relational codes of conduct or upset relational expectations
 - Rules
 - Expectations
- 1. Insensitivity to partner’s feelings or needs.
- 2. Deception
- 3. Infidelity
- Transgressions often result in hurt feelings
 - Hurt feelings tend to occur in relational contexts
 - Although strangers and acquaintances can cause hurt feelings, the most intense experiences of hurt feelings tend to come from close friends, family members, and romantic partners

Hurt feelings

Three variables predict intense hurt feelings:

1. Ability to respond
 - When people feel like they lack the ability to respond to a hurtful event, their hurt is usually intensified
2. Perceived intentionality
 - When people feel that a relational partner did something on purpose to hurt them, their hurt is usually intensified

{Exam 3 Material}

3. Degree to which hurt feelings were expected
 - When hurt feelings are unexpected, they tend to be most intense

Deception

- Occurs when people intentionally manage messages so that a receiver will understand something in a way that the sender thinks is false
- Deceptions are common in relationships
- Deceptions are common in everyday interactions
 - Up to 25% of daily interactions involve deception

Five types of deception

1. *Lies*:
the information given is opposite or clearly different from what the deceiver perceives as the truth.
2. *Equivocation*:
the information given is indirect, evasive, and/or ambiguous
 - Q: "Do you like my girlfriend?"
 - A: "She's very pretty!"
3. *Concealment*:
important information about an issue is left out
4. *Understatement*:
certain details of an issue are downplayed
5. *Exaggeration*:
information is overstated; details are sometimes added

Five common reasons why people engage in deception

1. Maintaining a relationship
 - Avoid hurting a partner's feelings
 - Avoid conflict
 - Preserve relationship
2. Managing face needs – for both themselves and their partner
 - positive or negative face needs
 - Enhance or protect self-image
 - Shield self from embarrassment or criticism
3. Managing dialectical tensions
 - Example: autonomy/connection: deceiving a partner to spend time alone
 - Example: openness/closed-ness: deceiving a partner to keep information private
4. Establishing relational control
 - Inducing guilt to manipulate a partner
 - Acting like you have better relational alternatives
 - Pretending feelings of love are not as deep as they really are
5. Continuing deception
 - Maintaining established lies

Deception detection accuracy is generally low (50% to 60% accuracy)

{Exam 3 Material}

Advantages of relational closeness – helps us detect deception

- Behavioral familiarity
 - We know how our partner typically behaves
- Informational familiarity
 - We have information about our partner

Disadvantages of relational closeness – hinders our ability to detect deception

- the truth bias
 - A tendency to judge more messages as truths than lies when liking is present
- Partner's behavioral control
- Partner's ability to control guilty behaviors to appear truthful

Deception in relationships are not always bad

Positive deceptions:

- In certain situations that do not relate directly to the relationship or one partner's view of the other, deception may help couples avoid arguments and hurt feelings
 - EXAMPLE:
Q: "Do you like my new haircut? I really like it a lot."
A: "It looks great!" (you do not like it)
- Positive illusion
 - "You are the most beautiful and sexy woman I have ever seen."
 - Exaggeration
 - Some idealization of partners is a key part of relationship maintenance

Negative deceptions:

- probably not great to engage in negative deceptions... relationships suffer
- Deceptions about topics that have a significant negative impact on the relationship (relationship-focused), or one partner's view of the other (self-focused).
- Examples:
 - *Infidelity, addiction, financial issues
- When people perceive their partners as dishonest, they report less relational satisfaction and commitment
- Deception is a leading cause of conflict and breakup in relationships

4 types of infidelity

1. Sexual infidelity

- occurs when someone engages in sexual activity outside of her/his committed relationship
- 20% to 40% of dating/cohabitating relationships are marked by sexual infidelity
 - Self-reported data

How common is sexual infidelity among married couples?

- GSS 2019 survey:
 - Have you had sex with someone other than your spouse while married?
 - 17.5% of married individuals said "yes."
 - The most recent data suggest that rates of sexual infidelity among heterosexual men and heterosexual women is very similar

{Exam 3 Material}

2. Emotional infidelity
 - occurs when someone is emotionally attached to or “in love with” a potential rival
 - May or may not have a sexual component
3. Communicative infidelity
 - occurs when people engage in sexual activity with a third party to communicate a message to their partner
 - Signal need for attention, means of revenge, message of dissatisfaction
4. Online infidelity
 - Romantic or sexual communication facilitated by internet use.
 - Some people do not consider online infidelity to be “real” infidelity

Why does infidelity occur (all types)?

- Relational dissatisfaction
- Boredom/need for excitement and variety
- Wanting to feel attractive
- Sexual incompatibility
- Revenge

Discovering Sexual Infidelity

1. Finding out from a third party or witnessing the infidelity firsthand
 - most relationship damage
 - likely very hurtful
 - Unexpected
 - Can't really respond
 - Perception of intentionality
2. Having the partner tell you on her or his own
 - least relationship damage
 - suggests partner feels badly/ guilty
 - We tend to be more forgiving if we perceive that the person who committed a transgression feels badly or guilty about what they have done
3. Having the partner admit to infidelity after you question her or him
 - falls in the middle in terms of relational damage

Impact of Infidelity

- Emotional distress
- Erosion of trust
- Lowered self-esteem
- Possible relationship dissolution

Given that infidelity is a relatively common experience in relationships:

1. How do people deal with it?
2. Are there any potential positive consequences of infidelity?
3. What does infidelity tell us about our relationships?

Jealousy

{Exam 3 Material}

- Jealousy is the result of a relational transgression, such as a partner having a sexual or emotional affair
- Jealousy can also be seen as a transgression in its own right, when a partner's suspicions are unfounded
 - What we will be discussing

Romantic jealousy

- occurs when an individual worries that a rival could interfere with the existence or quality of her/his relationship
 - “Steal” the partner away
 - Feeling insecure or fearful about the character of the relationship
 - Also feeling insecure about ourselves -- “I’m not going to be okay without my partner.”

Jealous Thoughts

Primary Appraisals:

General evaluations about the existence and quality of the threat

1. Does a rival exist?
 - Rival might be real or imagined
2. Is the rival a threat to the relationship?
 - Threat might be real or imagined

Secondary appraisals:

1. Motives for partner’s interest?
 - Why is my partner interested in the rival?
 - Real or imagined interest
2. Comparisons to the rival
 - Am I better than the rival?
 - Along dimensions of perceived importance
3. Evaluation of alternatives
 - What would I do without my partner? Be single? Date someone else?
4. Assessment of potential loss
 - How devastated would I be without my partner?

Why do people make primary and secondary appraisals?

- To plan coping strategies
 - Individuals often believe that jealousy will keep them from being surprised, help them defend their rights, and learn how their partner “really” feels

Fear and anger are most central

- Fear of losing partner
- Anger at partner, anger at rival, anger at self for not being able to “keep” partner

{Exam 3 Material}

Communicative Responses to Jealousy

1. Constructive Responses:

Integrative communication

- Calm, direct, non-aggressive way of disclosing feelings and asking for an explanation

Compensatory restoration

- Doing something to improve self
 - New interests, hobbies, appearance
- Doing something to improve the relationship
 - Pro-social maintenance behaviors
 - Active listening

2. Destructive responses:

Negative communication

- Arguing, cold looks, sarcasm

Violent communication

- Violent threats or actual violence

Counterjealousy inductions

- Trying to make partner jealous
 - Communicative infidelity

3. Avoidant Responses:

- Denial of jealous feelings
- Silence about jealous feelings

4. Rival-Focused Responses:

- Signs of possession
 - Verbally and non-verbally Communicating to others that the partner is “taken”
- Derogating competitors
 - Making fun of the rival
- Rival contacts
 - Communicating with rival

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24.3

Relational Transgressions

Obsessive Relational Intrusion (ORI)

- Repeated and unwanted pursuit and invasion of one's sense of physical or symbolic privacy by another person, either stranger or acquaintance, who desires and/or presumes an intimate relationship
- Persistent Unwanted Behavior
- Lack of Consent or Reciprocity

{Exam 3 Material}

- Intrusiveness
 - This can manifest as unwanted attention, invasion of privacy, and disregard for personal space or autonomy
- Common ORI situations involve unrequited love between:
 - Acquaintances
 - Former relational partners
 - One person wants the relationship to continue
 - One person wanting a platonic friendship to turn romantic
- Examples of ORI behaviors:
 - Common Forms
 - repeated calls and/or texts
 - repeated social media posts
 - repeatedly asking for another chance
 - watching from a distance
 - making exaggerated claims of affection
 - Severe Forms (commonly known as stalking):
 - invading one's home
 - damaging property
 - causing physical harm

23.3

Components of ORI

1. Lack of Mutual agreement regarding the nature or even the existence of a relationship
2. ORI is not associated with a singular event, but is repeated
 - a. Pursuit is persistent despite the absence of reciprocity by the other person and despite resistance by the other person
 - b. The episodes of unwanted behavior tend to escalate over time, with the seriousness rising and the time between incidents shortening

Motivations for ORI

- ORIs may stem from feelings of infatuation, obsession and a belief that the relationship is meant to be, despite evidence to the contrary
- They can also be driven by a desire for control, possessiveness, or a need for validation

Impact of ORI:

- ORIs can have significant negative effects on the target individual's well-being
- They may experience fear, anxiety, stress, and a sense of helplessness or vulnerability
- It can also interfere with their ability to feel safe and secure in their own lives

Reasons for ORI

1. Relational scripts, particularly those regarding the establishment of romantic/sexual relationships, often idealize and reward persistence
2. Indirect or ambiguous communication

{Exam 3 Material}

- a. It can be very difficult to tell another person you are not interested in them when they are clearly interested in you
- b. In most instances, we don't want to hurt another person's feelings, so we use indirect or ambiguous communication
 - i. Which may be misinterpreted
 - 1. "This person is just playing hard to get."
 - 2. Another cultural script that may encourage ORI
- Unrequited love can cause an individual to fixate on a desired person and "justify" (in their own minds) the use of unhealthy pursuit strategies

Flirting behaviors can turn into ORI behaviors if:

- The flirtee repeatedly indicates he/she is not interested
- The flirtee repeatedly does not reciprocate the flirting behaviors
- The flirter feels like he/she is having to work very hard to get the other person's attention

Relational Goal Pursuit Theory

- Theory that explains why ORI behaviors occur
 - Three parts
- 1. People expend energy to develop or re-initiate relationships to the extent that they perceive a relationship is desirable and attainable
- 2. When a relationship is perceived to be unattainable, people abandon their original goal and seek an alternative
- 3. ORI behaviors are most likely when people continue to believe a relationship is attainable even though it is not
- People who use ORIs in an attempt to get closer to another person:
- Mentally link the desired relationship to exaggerated feelings of happiness and exaggerated feeling of self-worth
 - "I will never be happy unless he/she goes out with me."
 - "I know I am a good person if he/she goes out with me."
- These mental links also produces exaggerated negative feelings toward failing to "win" the other person over
 - "I am worthless unless he/she goes out with me."
- These mental links tend to discourage people from stopping their ORI behaviors and tend to mentally reinforce the importance of a relationship with the other person

The Investment Model of Relationship Maintaining Behavior

- Predicts that level of commitment helps to buffer relationships against the effects of transgressions
- Why do some relationships survive transgressions while others do not?

{Exam 3 Material}

- According to IMRMB, the answer is commitment

Level of commitment involves three components:

1. Satisfaction
 - a. Satisfaction is based on:
 - i. Rewards, costs, outcomes, and comparison levels
 - b. Outcome: reward-cost ratio
 - c. Comparison level: how rewarding or costly you expect your relationship to be relative to your perceptions of other relationships
 - i. How do you think your relationship compares to other people's relationships?
 - d. Satisfaction occurs when:
 - i. rewards outweigh costs
 - ii. the outcome (reward-cost ratio) is as good as or better than the comparison level
 - iii. Satisfaction predicts commitment
2. Investments
 - a. Investments are unrecoverable inputs that individuals deposit into relationships
 - i. What are you putting into the relationship?
 - b. Two types of investments
 1. Intrinsic investments: resources put directly into the relationship (time, effort)
 - i. Likely intangible
 2. Extrinsic investments: resources developed over time as a result of being in the relationship (possessions, social networks)
 - i. Likely tangible
 - c. High investment (both types) predicts commitment
 - i. Much more to lose if relationship ends
3. Alternatives
 - a. Considering one's relational options
 - i. Would I be better off with someone else? quality of alternatives?
 - ii. Would I be better off single?
 - b. Perception of poor alternatives predicts commitment
 - i. "I can't do any better."
 - ii. Also explains why people stay in unsatisfying relationships
 - c. Perception of good alternatives predict less commitment
 - i. "There are other fish in the sea."

Commitment is predicted by:

- High satisfaction
- High investment
- Poor quality of alternatives

Pro-Relationship Behaviors

- Behaviors used intentionally to maintain a relationship
- Committed couples are more likely to engage in pro-relationship behaviors

{Exam 3 Material}

1. Deciding to Remain
 - a. Commitment predicts making the choice to not exit a relationship after transgressions have taken place
2. Accommodating the Partner
 - a. Commitment predicts making the choice to resist engaging in negative reciprocity
3. Derogating Alternatives
 - a. Commitment predicts will actively find fatal faults with other potential partners
4. Being Willing to Make Sacrifices
 - a. Commitment predicts making choices about one's time, money, career, and living situation with the relationship in mind
5. Perceiving Relationship Superiority
 - a. Commitment predicts that couples choose to believe that their relationship is better than others' relationships

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25.2

Relational Redefinition

Instead of reconciling, some former romantic partners redefine their relationships

- Examples:
 - spouses become co-parents
 - a romantic relationship is redefined as a friendship

When spouses become co-parents

- ~12% regard themselves as good friends 5 years after the divorce
- Friendship is more likely if the divorce was non-adversarial
- Adversarial around children, resources (money, possessions, real estate)

When romantic partners become friends

- Most dating couples do not continue any type of relationship after breaking up
- Among those who do remain friends:
 - around 60% showed a pattern of relationship decline over time (with commitment to the friendship declining in the months after the break up)
 - about 21% of ex-couples became better friends over time
- Former romantic couples are more likely to be successful in transitioning to a friendship if they:
 - engage in reflective talk
 - realize that they can be happy just being friends
- exchange social support
- communicate forgiveness for actions that occurred when they were a couple

**Divorce rate has been consistent in the past decade

{Exam 3 Material}

- somewhere between 40 and 50% of first marriages end in divorce
- for second and third marriages, 60 to 70% end in divorce

Why do couples get divorced? 17 year panel survey

- Panel survey – data collected from the same people at multiple points in time
 - 17 year panel study
 - 1980, 1983, 1988, 1992, 1997
 - Limitation: only heterosexual couples
1. Infidelity (21.6% of divorces)
 - a. Sexual infidelity
 - b. Emotional infidelity
 2. Incompatibility (19.2% of divorces)
 - a. “birds of a feather” vs. “opposites attract.”
 - b. Beliefs about money, children, sex, religion
 - i. the big four
 - c. similarity is a big prediction of relationship development
 3. Alcohol or drug abuse (10.6% of divorces)
 - a. Violence
 - b. Legal problems

Which communication patterns predict dissolution?

1. Withdrawal – associated with the demand-withdraw pattern
 - a. Lack of supportiveness
 - b. Lack of listening
 - c. Infrequent time spent together
2. Negative communication
 - a. Unconstructive criticism, use of negative conflict styles
 - b. Frequency of conflict does not predict level of satisfaction; conflict style predicts level of satisfaction
3. Lack of verbal and non-verbal intimacy
 - a. Low levels of disclosure
 - b. Low levels of touch
4. Gottman’s Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse
 - a. contempt, defensiveness, stonewalling, criticism
5. Abusive communication
 - a. Name calling, insults, physical violence

If abusive communication predicts dissolution, why do some people stay with their abuser?

Three common explanations include:

1. Financial dependence
 - a. Perceived or real
2. Family history of violence

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- a. "This is how marriages are."
- b. a lot of how we perceive relationships is intergenerational
3. Psychological variables
 - a. low self-esteem
 - b. "It's my fault."
 - c. "I don't deserve better than this"

Intergenerational Transmission of Divorce

- Data-supported idea that children of divorced parents are more likely to get divorced themselves
- More likely if:
 - both partners are from divorced parents
 - divorce occurred before either partner was younger than age 12

1. Children of divorced parents may be exposed to poor models of dyadic behavior and communication
 - a. May not learn skills and attitudes that facilitate successful functioning in marital roles
2. Children of divorced parents may be predisposed to develop traits that exacerbate relationship tension
 - a. Issues with trust, commitment

Duck's Process Model of Dissolution

- Focuses on communication processes that occur prior to, during, and after breakups
- Stage model
 - Limitation: not all relationships go through stages
 - We will address this

Five phases

1. Intrapsychic*
2. Dyadic*
3. Social
4. Grave dressing
5. Resurrection

1. Intrapsychic

- a. Triggered by relational dissatisfaction or discomfort
- b. There is something wrong. Partner keeps it to him/herself
 - i. Rumination occurs, stays in your own head
- c. This phase can involve:
 - i. Mentally weighing costs and rewards of relationship
 - ii. Withdrawal, being secretive, and contemplation

2. Dyadic Phase

- a. Presentation of dissatisfaction to partner

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- b. Arguments and discussions with partner about what is wrong
 - c. Discussions and arguments might lead to addressing the dissatisfaction and solving the problem
 - i. Negotiate and reconcile differences
 - ii. If successful, process stops here
 - d. Or, discussions and arguments might lead to the realization that the relationship is not worth saving
 - i. In which case, on to phase 3
3. Social Phase
- a. Couple “goes public” about the problems in their relationship
 - i. Social networks (friends and family) find out about the relationship problems
 - b. The phase can involve:
 - i. Seeking support from social network
 - ii. Complaining about the partner to others
 - iii. Face-saving efforts (telling one’s side of the story)
 - iv. Preparing the social network for a possible breakup
4. Grave Dressing Phase
- a. Focus on coping with the breakup in a socially acceptable way
 - b. Partners create an acceptable story about their love and loss
 - c. This phase can involve:
 - i. Developing and refining the “break up story” for different audiences
 - ii. More face-saving communication (often differs for the initiator vs. the dumpee)
5. Resurrection Phase
- a. Finding closure and moving on
 - b. It includes:
 - i. Visualizing the future without the partner
 - ii. Taking lessons away from the experience
 - iii. Revising the breakup story
 - iv. Exploring new alternatives

{In class video}

The impact of divorce on children

- It depends- no one effect
- **Conflict style is much more important than the presence of divorce
- **getting divorced and having peace is probably better for the kid
- The most important thing you can do is listen to your child’s voice

3/28/2024

26.2

Disengagement and Termination

{Exam 3 Material}

Sudden Death

- *The Catastrophe Model*
 - Contrary to the Process Model, some relationships do not gradually unwind through stages, but instead are characterized by sudden death
- *Sudden death* = relationship ended because of a single critical event
- Such events include:
 - Infidelity
 - Serious arguments
 - Physical violence

Negative Outcomes of Relationship Breakups

- Negative emotions, loneliness, physical symptoms
 - Depression, anger, guilt, confusion
 - Emotional pain can feel like physical pain
- Financial consequences
 - Two living situations instead of one
 - Legal fees (if applicable)
 - Alimony (if applicable)
 - Child support (if applicable)
- Effects on Children
 - Living with feuding parents versus dealing with a divorce
 - Divorce can have negative effects on children, but it is generally better for children than living with parents in constant conflict
- Health Consequences
 - Divorced people have more health problems than married, single, dating, or cohabitating people

Positive Outcomes of Relationship Breakups

- Personal Positives
 - increased self-sufficiency
 - understanding that you are able to handle life on your own
- Relational Positives:
 - knowing more about how to communicate with romantic partners
 - gaining more knowledge about how to develop, maintain, and terminate relationships
- Environmental Positives
 - being able to concentrate more on school, work, and friends
- Future Positives
 - knowing what one wants (and does not want) in future relationships

“First big fight”

- An episode of conflict during which couples recall mutually dealing with:
 - Negative feelings about the relationship
 - Doubts about the relationship

{Exam 3 Material}

- Disappointments in the relationship
- Unmet expectations about the relationship
- Negative assessments of the relationship
- “First big fights” are typically memorable because:
 1. Of the intensity of the fight – feeling that it could end the relationship
 2. The timing of the fight – either occurring after the couple has decided to be exclusive or during the process of deciding to be exclusive.

What leads to the first big fight?

1. Uncertainty - feeling unsure about your ability to predict or explain someone’s attitudes and behaviors
 - a. Partner uncertainty - uncertainty about your partner's feelings and intentions
 - i. Does this person reciprocate my feelings and desires?
 - b. Relational uncertainty - uncertainty about the general state of your relationship
 - i. Is this going well?
2. Feelings of jealousy
 - a. often sparked by potential rival
3. Negative violation of expectations
 - a. partner surprises you in an unpleasant way
4. Feelings of incompatibility
 - a. personality
 - b. Insurmountable differences in background

Effects of the first big fight

1. Clarification of feelings
 - a. for partner
 - b. for relationship
2. Feelings on interdependence
 - a. realization of the need for relationship maintenance
3. Introduction of *thematic conflict*
 - a. What you will be fighting about for the duration of the relationship

Survivors vs. Non-survivors

Couples who survived their first big fight

- experienced decrease in uncertainty
- greater understanding of the partner
- Tended to use direct, cooperative communication
- Dyadic attributions
 - Emphasis on shared history
 - Emphasis on the relationship as a unit
 - Use of “we”

Couples who broke up:

- Experienced greater uncertainty
- Were unwilling to talk about why the fight occurred
- Were surprised by several aspects of the conflict, including their partner’s behavior

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- Individual attributions
 - Emphasis on self
 - Use of “I”
- Perceived that they had irreconcilable differences
- (falsely) believed that the differences would work out on their own, without discussion
 - *Cumulative annoyance* – tolerating irritating behaviors up until a certain point. At that point, a conflict occurs

27.3

4/1/2024

Breakups

- Assuming the relationship involved some level of intimacy and commitment, breakups are emotionally challenging
- There is no “magic” way of breaking up

Ways to classify breakups

- Direct vs. indirect
 - Direct = unambiguous verbal communication
 - Indirect = ambiguous verbal (e.g., hinting) and non-verbal communication
- Unilateral vs. bilateral
 - Unilateral = from one person
 - Bilateral = joint decision

Unilateral, Indirect strategies for ending relationships

- Avoidance, aka “ghosting”
 - Most common, especially for low commitment relationships
 - Less time and less emotionally stressful for the ghoster
 - Uncertainty-producing and likely distressing for the ghostee
 - Unanswered texts, leaving a partner on “read,” social media cleansing (unfriending, blocking, etc.) , ceasing face-to-face contact
- Third party manipulation
 1. Having a third party break up with the partner for you
 2. Leaking breakup to social network
 3. Engaging in behaviors that are designed to let the partner know you are interested in breaking up.
 - This strategy typically creates a great deal of anger.
 - Possibility of post-breakup friendship is very low
- Pseudo De-Escalation
 - “Let’s put some space into the relationship” (or something similar) really means “This relationship is over.”
 - Usually, the intent behind this strategy is to let the partner down easily
 - However, it is still manipulative and likely confusing and filled with uncertainty for the dumpee
- Cost escalation
 - Making being in the relationship less desirable

{Exam 3 Material}

- Acting like a jerk

Unilateral, Direct strategies for ending relationships

- The Direct Dump
 - Can be hard to hear if unexpected
 - Little uncertainty
 - Often used if other strategies have not worked (e.g., after avoidance).
- Justification
 - Explanation of why partner wants to break up
 - Low possibility of uncertainty
 - Potentially less face threatening
 - Assuming explanation was about the dumper, not the dumpee
 - “I need to focus on school right now and I can’t give this relationship the attention it deserves.”
- Relationship Talk Trick
 - “We need to talk.”
 - One person wants to break up with the other and goes into the conversation with that goal in mind
 - Often combined with the justification strategy

Bilateral, Direct strategies for ending relationships

- The “blame game.”
 - Partners blame each other for the break up
 - Potentially face-saving
 - But usually full of conflict
- The Negotiated Farewell
 - Long-term couples
 - Ending the relationship fairly (resources, children, pets)
 - Involves discussion and co-operation

Coping with Post-break up grief

- Grief is not a passive experience, but a series of active choices for the grieving person to confront and resolve in either the direction of healing or prolonged suffering

Weber’s **four** central tasks of grief

1. Expression of emotions (e.g., sorrow or rage)
 - a. Supportive social network is very important here.
2. Review relationship and accept the reasons for its failure
 - a. What happened?
 - b. What went wrong?
 - c. Why did it not work out?
3. Don’t idealize former partner
 - a. It is normal to miss the partner, but be careful not to idealize him/her
 - b. When you accept that your ex-partner had flaws, it is easier to leave him or her behind
4. Prepare to feel better

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- a. The breakup is likely hard, but remember that it may be a relief
- b. It is okay to start feeling better
 - i. Humor helps healing

28.5

4/3/2024

Print AD Dating

- First personal ads – England, late 1600s

Video AD Dating

Coping with Post-break up grief {Ted talk}

- You mind plays tricks on you
 - trying to figure it out will hold you back
- Your cognitive abilities are not what they usually are in this period

Online dating has a history

- 1959 Stanford
 - matchmaking service for a class project
- 1965 Harvard
 - ppl paid 3\$

The Math of Dating Apps for Heterosexual Users

1. There are more men than women on dating apps
2. Men give more likes than women
3. A small share of the users get a big share of the likes

Why do people use Tinder?

1. Love
2. Casual Sex
3. Ease of communication
4. Self-worth validation

Tinder as a game

- Tinder may be appealing because it “game-ifies” interactions
- Based on basic psychology
 - Looking at faces may be pleasurable
 - Easy decision making
 - Matches offer validation
 - Messages are potential positive surprises

Dating app positives

- dating apps can be convenient and may be an efficient way to meet potential partners

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- Dating apps can help connect people
 - Diverse interests
 - LGBTQ+ people, particularly in non-urban areas

Dating app negatives

- Dating apps have been linked to negative mental health outcomes (Holtzhausen et al., 2020)
- Dating apps may encourage ORI behaviors, particularly directed toward women (Phan et al., 2021)
- Deception and catfishing (Markowitz & Hancock, 2018).

The Hyperpersonal Model

- explains how computer-mediated communication (CMC), such as interactions on the internet or through digital platforms, can lead to an even more intense and idealized form of interpersonal communication compared to face-to-face communication
- This model suggests that in certain online interactions, individuals may receive more personalized and selective information, leading to heightened perceptions of intimacy and connection

Selective Self-Presentation:

- In online interactions, individuals have greater control over the information they choose to disclose about themselves

Over-attribution of Similarities:

- Online communicators tend to overemphasize similarities and commonalities, as the limited information available may lead to assumptions or projections
- This can create a sense of shared understanding and connection, even if it might not be as accurate as face-to-face interactions.

Anonymity and Reduced Cues:

- The relative anonymity of online communication can lead individuals to feel more comfortable expressing themselves without the social constraints often present in face-to-face interactions

Idealization of the Communicator:

- Due to the selective nature of online communication, individuals may idealize the person they are interacting with, projecting positive qualities onto them

****Research backed Advice**

- Nothing wrong with meeting someone on an app
- However, take the interaction from online to offline fairly quickly
- Red flag if they only want to talk online
- Avoid hyperpersonal model issues

{Exam 3 Material}

SINGLE PEOPLE

- Over 30% of the US population is single
 - <https://www.pewresearch.org/social-trends/2020/08/20/a-profile-of-single-americans/>
- In 2021, the median age to marry for the first time was 30.4 for men and 28.6 for women
 - (<https://www.census.gov/newsroom/press-releases/2021/families-and-living-arrangements.html>)

Are single people looking for a partner?

- Some are- but many are not
- About half of daters are open to either a relationship or casual dates

Why are single people single?- Pew Research Center

1. "I have more important priorities right now"
2. "I just like being single"
3. "Im too busy"

Why are single people single?- Apostolou et al. (2020)

1. "I am not good at flirting"
2. "I want to be free to do what i wanty"
3. "I fear I will get hurt"

ARE SINGLE PEOPLE LONELY?

- Some single people are lonely
- However, research shows that most are not (DePaulo, 2019)
 - Single people engage in more relationship maintenance behaviors than married people with friends, siblings, and parents.
 - Single people report "full blown" attachments to friends, siblings, and parents
 - Secure base, safe haven, proximity-seeking, and separation protes

ARE SINGLE PEOPLE MORE DEPRESSED THAN MARRIED PEOPLE?

- No – most research shows no difference between single and married people in terms of divorce (St. John & Montgomery, 2009)
 - Some research shows a difference, but only for men.

ARE SINGLE PEOPLE LESS HAPPY THAN MARRIED PEOPLE?

- No. Research comparing single and married people shows very little difference between the two groups (Lucas et al., 2003)
 - Happiness may increase slightly in the "honeymoon phase" of the marriage
 - People who were happy with their lives before marriage are people who are happy with their lives after marriage

ARE SINGLE PEOPLE LESS HEALTHY THAN MARRIED PEOPLE?

{Exam 3 Material}

- Relationships, including marriage, predict positive health outcomes (Tumin, 2017)
 - Stress buffering model
 - Main effects model
- However, divorce predicts negative health outcomes
 - Divorce impacts roughly 50% of American marriages

SINGLE STEREOTYPES AND DISCRIMINATION

- On average, married men make more money than single men
- Many employment and government benefits favor married people
- Single people are often stereotyped as selfish, immature, and less well-adjusted than married people

RELATIONSHIP EXPECTATIONS

- Unrealistic expectations can undermine romantic relationships
- One person cannot meet all of your needs
- Couples need time apart
- Although relationships involve merged identities, it is important to maintain a sense of self

FRIENDSHIPS

- Friendships differ from other types of close relationships because:
 1. They are voluntary
 2. They (typically) lack the pressures associated with a romantic relationship
 3. They are non-exclusive
 4. They (typically) lack formal rituals

FUNCTIONS OF FRIENDSHIP

1. Friends offer a sense of inclusiveness and belonging
 - a. Families do, as well, but the voluntary nature of friendship makes it distinctive.
2. Friends offer support
 - a. Emotional, esteem, physical
3. Friends provide opportunities for communication
 - a. Range of topics discussed may be broader than romantic or family relationships
4. Reinforce identity
 - a. Friends help us feel positively about who we are

FRIENDSHIP TYPES

- Acquaintance friends
 - Individuals who are in frequent contact but do not know each other very well and interact in superficial ways
 - Low levels of intimacy
 - Low levels of disclosure
- Casual friends
 - Disclose carefully and cautiously
 - Self-presentation is important
 - Avoid discussion of personal or sensitive topics

{Exam 3 Material}

- Agentic friendships
 - pragmatic friendships that typically revolve around a common task, goal, or passion
 - utilitarian
 - often develop strong bonds quickly because they share a common goal
- True friendships
 - express authentic emotions to each other without fear of judgment or rejection
 - high levels of disclosure
 - high levels of intimacy
 - verbal and non-verbal affection

How do we choose friends?

1. Perceived similarity
2. Proximity
 - a. possibilities for interaction
3. Attraction
 - a. social, task, physical

Rawlins Six Stages of Friendships

- Explain the process by which individuals become true friends
- Stage model
 1. Role-limited interaction
 - a. Individuals interact with others based on our social roles.
 - b. The communication is characterized by a focus on superficial, rather than personal topics.
 - c. Limited self-disclosure
 2. Friendly Relations
 - a. Communication moves beyond initial roles
 - b. participants begin to interact with one another to see if there are common interests, as well as an interest to continue getting to know one another
 3. Moving towards friendship
 - a. participants make moves to foster a more personalized friendship
 - b. They may begin meeting outside of the setting in which the relationship started, and begin increasing the levels of self-disclosure
 4. Nascent Friendship
 - a. individuals commit to spending more time together.
 - b. may start using the term “friend” to refer to each other
 - c. The interactions extend beyond the initial roles as participants work out their own private communication rules and norms
 5. Stabilized Friendship
 - a. In this stage, friends take each other for granted as friends, not in a negative way
 - b. Assume each other will be in their lives
 - c. The communication in this stage is also characterized by a sense of trust, as levels of self-disclosure increase and each person feels more comfortable revealing parts of him or herself to the other
 - d. This stage can continue indefinitely throughout a lifetime

{Exam 3 Material}

6. Waning Friendship
 - a. Friendship declines
 - b. Perhaps the relationship is too difficult to sustain over large geographic distances
 - c. Or, sometimes people change and grow in different directions and have little in common with old friends